and the Bengal famine. Purshotamdas wrote to Walchand Hirachand who was the leading organizer that such festivity in hard times was best avoided as it would lead to justified criticism. In his letter he said that the condition in Bombay could not be such as to justify any avoidable waste of either food grains or eatables. 'We can meet without the attraction of any eatables to express our feelings of satisfaction at Deshmukh's appointment, and if you propose to do that, I see no objection; but I am afraid we must not lend ourselves to any reasonable criticism if we can avoid it.'[28]

However, the proposed cancellation drew a protest from M.R. Jayakar who had not been consulted and did not share Purshotamdas's views. Deshmukh himself was keen to attend. Walchand changed his mind and arranged the dinner on October 25, 1943. Deshmukh says he explained the position to Purshotamdas 'who understood'. Those who attended included J.R.D Tata, Jehangir Patel, and Verrier Elwin, and it was decided to arrange a special dinner to raise funds for Elwin's work among the scheduled tribes of C.P. and Berar and Bihar and Orissa.[29] More celebration was in store for Deshmukh when he was knighted in January 1944. As Deshmukh observed in his memoirs, 'The knighthood came hopefully in advance of my vindicating my selection as Governor… In the context of the lack of accord over my appointment on the part of the Government of India, it also meant that the hatchet had been buried.'[30]

In 1945, Deshmukh was able to repay Purshotamdas for his support when fresh elections to the Central Board were to take place. Deshmukh had received a letter from Purshotamdas informing him of his unwillingness to canvass and get into the rough and tumble of an election. Purshotamdas had also written to Kasturbhai Lalbhai and suggested the advisability of consulting Sardar Patel in the matter. Purshotamdas was hesitant to stand for election since 'I have worked for ten years there and feel that I have done my bit of duty.'[31] His rival was C.B. Mehta, a well-known bullion dealer. Deshmukh himself felt concerned at the 'possible replacement of a seasoned business statesman like Purshotamdas by a thrusting market operator in bullion.'[32] A few days later, accompanied by B.M. Birla, he called on the Sardar who had just been released from jail. Sardar Patel remembered Deshmukh from the Wardha episode in 1939 and asked if he could do anything for him. Deshmukh told him about the matter of Purshotamdas's election. The taciturn leader made a brief reply: 'I shall see